

Make the Decision Visible

A ninety-minute workshop pattern for turning a cloudy discussion into a decision people can repeat.

AUTHOR	Example Facilitation Studio
ISSUED	August 2026

Contents

Use this pattern when	1
The ninety-minute arc	1
Run of show	2
Before people arrive.....	2
Facilitation moves	2
Reveal: make the disagreement legible	2
Shape: compare choices using the same lens	2
Commit: say what changed	3
Printable decision canvas	3
Decision canvas.....	3
Close the room well.....	3

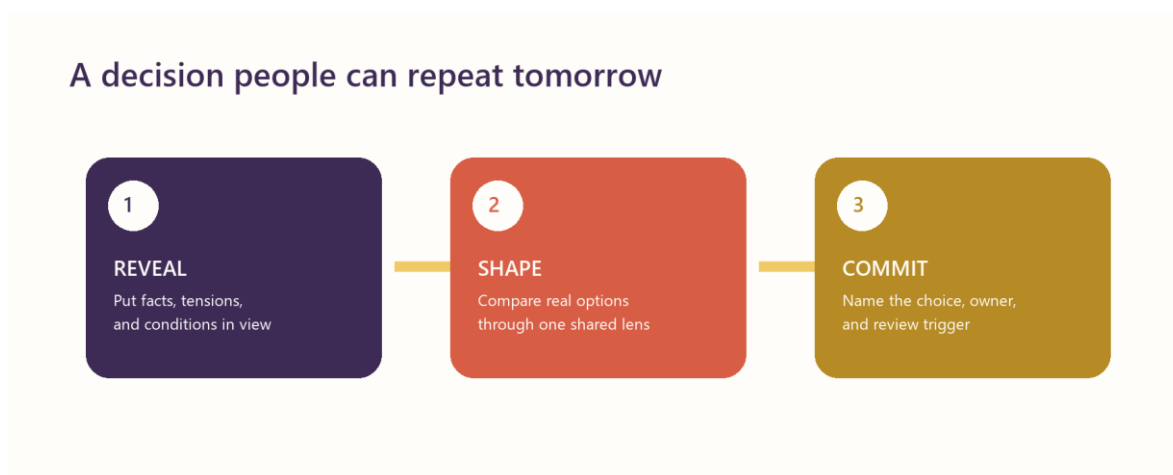
Use this pattern when

A group has discussed the same question more than once, several answers sound reasonable, and nobody can state what would make one option better than another.

This pattern does not manufacture agreement. It gives the disagreement a visible shape, makes the decision rule explicit, and ends with a named owner and next checkpoint.

Do not invite a group to decide something that has already been decided elsewhere. If the room can only advise, say so before the first activity.

The ninety-minute arc



The session moves from evidence to choice to ownership

The arc has three movements. **Reveal** puts the evidence and tensions on the wall. **Shape** turns preferences into comparable choices. **Commit** records the decision in language another person could repeat tomorrow.

Run of show

The schedule is maintained in Excel so timing can be adjusted without editing the prose or rebuilding a Word table by hand.

Minutes	Movement	Facilitator action	Visible output
0–10	Frame	State the decision boundary and what the room can influence	One decision sentence
10–30	Reveal	Collect facts, concerns, and conditions without debate	Clustered evidence wall
30–55	Shape	Name options and compare them through agreed criteria	Comparable option cards
55–75	Commit	Select, test the wording, and name an owner	Decision record
75–90	Close	Repeat the choice, list open work, confirm the review trigger	Shared next step

Before people arrive

Prepare one decision sentence with a blank:

By the end of this session, we will decide _____ so that _____.

Then prepare the room:

- one wall or board that everyone can see;
- one card per option;
- a visible timer;
- a parking area for important questions that do not change today's decision.

Facilitation moves

Reveal: make the disagreement legible

Ask each person to write one fact, one concern, and one condition for a good outcome. Cluster duplicates before discussion. The facilitator names the clusters without interpreting them.

Shape: compare choices using the same lens

Write the decision criteria before scoring any option. If a criterion appears only after a preferred option performs badly, pause and test whether the criterion is real or tactical.

Commit: say what changed

The final record needs four elements:

1. the choice;
2. the reason it won;
3. the owner of the next action;
4. the date or event that triggers a review.

Printable decision canvas

The canvas below is a native Word fragment. It stays editable as a designed worksheet and can be changed independently of this Markdown source.

Decision canvas

Complete the four boxes before the session closes. Use short, observable language.

THE CHOICE We decided...	WHY THIS OPTION It best meets...
OWNER + NEXT ACTION Name / action / due point...	REVIEW TRIGGER We will revisit this when...

Close the room well

Read the decision aloud. Ask one person who did not lead the discussion to repeat it in their own words. If their version changes the meaning, the record is not clear enough yet.

End by naming what remains unresolved. A good close does not pretend every concern disappeared; it separates the decision from the work that follows.